

‘On Our Way Home from the Revolution: Reflections on Ukraine’ Helps Untangle the History Behind the Russian-Ukraine War

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Sonya Bilocerkowycz’s “On Our Way Home from the Revolution: Reflections on Ukraine” provides a lens for understanding the historical context behind the Russian-Ukraine war. Through her deeply honest prose, Bilocerkowycz imparts upon the reader an appreciation for Ukrainian national identity while acknowledging the country’s complicated past.

“On Our Way Home from the Revolution” is an essay collection exploring Ukrainian national identity authored by former Ohio State Graduate Student, Sonya Bilocerkowycz. Written in the wake of the illegal Russian annexation of Crimea in 2014, “On Our Way Home” is invaluable for understanding the complex historical dynamic at work in the Russian-Ukraine war today.

Bilocerkowycz begins “On Our Way Home” by introducing us to “The Village,” her family’s ancestral home prior to their emigration from Ukraine. The Village becomes a major setting throughout the work, host to a number of anecdotes relating to Bilocerkowycz’s travels in Ukraine. In the opening chapter however, The Village is characterized by a feeling of uneasiness as Soviet authorities come to arrest the village elder. The complex dynamic between Ukrainians and their Soviet (eventually Russian) neighbors is a relationship Bilocerkowycz continually revisits throughout her work.

Bilocerkowycz continues “On Our Way Home from the Revolution” by sharing her experiences at the Euromaidan (or, Maidan Uprising) which took place in Kyiv during the winter of 2013-2014. The Euromaidan protests were a result of the Ukrainian government refusing to sign the European Union–Ukraine Association Agreement, instead caving to pressure to sign an agreement that furthered ties with Russia. This resulted in widespread protests against government corruption and human rights abuses in Ukraine. While there, Bilocerkowycz describes the air around the Euromaidan as “taut and dangerous” (28), a fitting description as Ukraine fought to implement democracy.

In addition to her personal anecdotes, Bilocerkowycz explores what she sees as intangibles of Ukrainian identity. She believes Ukrainian identity must be contextualized by their status as a former Soviet state. In fact, many aspects of Ukrainian identity are still defined by this dynamic. As Busia, Bilocerkowycz’s grandmother who emigrated from Ukraine, watches the news in Chicago, she dotingly reminds Sonya to be careful “not to open the door for plumbers and electricians—even if something is broken—because servicemen have a nasty habit of being strangers” (40). Bilocerkowycz attributes this protectiveness to Busia’s upbringing, writing, “Busia is afraid because of The Village” (41). As a girl, Busia’s father was taken away by the NKVD, a precursor to the infamous KGB. With that in mind, it’s no wonder Busia takes on a protective role in Bilocerkowycz’s life.

One of the most powerful aspects of “On Our Way Home from the Revolution” is Bilocerkowycz’s representation of the Ukrainian national identity, an identity which is currently under attack by the Russian Federation and Vladimir Putin.

On February 20, 2022, Russia launched what it called a ‘special military operation’ to ‘denazify’ Ukraine. Putin has openly accused the democratically elected government of Ukraine of being [Pro-Nazi](#), even accusing Biden of the ‘Nazification’ of Ukraine. Putin’s claims of denazifying Ukraine are a weak pretext for his imperialist war. Firstly, democratically elected Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky is Jewish. Secondly, Russian missile strikes targeted the Babyn Yar Holocaust Memorial [in early March](#). Though Russia touts its [victory over Nazi Germany](#) in WWII, they have no concern destroying sites hallowed to the Jewish people and the memory of the Holocaust. Furthermore, Putin’s ‘special military operation,’ a misnomer, is the largest war on the European continent since WWII. Putin, and by extension the Russian Federation, began this illegal war with the intent of destroying Ukraine as an identity, sovereign nation, and people.

One of Bilocerkowycz’s essays, “Instructions for Parents in Upbringing Children,” is based on a Ukrainian pamphlet from the days of Soviet rule. The first instruction is, “Explain to children that Russians are not our older brothers, and neither are they our guardians or liberators. Russian Bolsheviks are enemies of the Ukrainian people; they are exploiters and oppressors!” This document, written in 1950, represents Ukrainian desire to express their national identity and culture, a right not granted under Soviet rule or illegal Russian occupation.

For evidence of Russia’s intent to suppress Ukrainian identity, look no further than hateful rhetoric spouted on Russian state media. Anton Krasovsky, a Russian state reporter, made these [series of comments](#) on RT, a Russian State Media Outlet, on October 23, 2022:

“Shove them (slur for Ukrainians) right into those huts and burn them up... They [Ukrainians who resisted Soviet rule] should have all been drowned in the river, right there, where the duckling swims. Just drown those children, drown them right in the river.”

This genocidal rhetoric must not be tolerated, especially as the Russian Federation comes under fire for a slew of war crimes committed in Ukraine. Since 2014, there have been 21,000 documented war crimes committed by Russian forces, according to Nobel Peace Prize winning organization [Centre for Civil Liberties](#). Although Krasovsky was later reprimanded and apologized for these comments, they are indicative of the Kremlin’s overarching strategy to use war crimes as a means of terror in Ukraine. By subjecting the Ukrainian people to beatings, torture, rape, extrajudicial killings, and mass executions (as seen in [Bucha](#)), Russia aims to terrorize the Ukrainian people into submission.

Unfortunately, cyclical violence and oppression are often linked with Ukrainian national identity, as Bilocerkowycz writes, “During... my grandmother’s youth, her home village was shuffled between the hands of three occupiers: first the Poles, then the Soviets, the Germans, and the Soviets again. She and my grandfather lived on the front lines of a world war, the territory that Timothy Snyder calls ‘the bloodlands’... Between 1933 and 1945 there was no more dangerous place in the world than Ukraine. More people were killed... in Ukraine than anywhere else in the world.” Because of the actions of Vladimir Putin, Ukrainians once again find themselves faced

with unwanted violence and oppression. By suppressing Ukrainian culture through military force, Putin hopes the Ukrainian people will abandon their language and identity rather than face the violence and terror that accompanies it.

Over the past weeks, Russian strikes throughout Ukraine have targeted critical energy infrastructure as the country prepares for what is sure to be a brutal winter. By denying civilians access to basic needs, Putin hopes to break the will of the Ukrainian people and their will to fight. Now more than ever, it is critical that Western Allies support Ukraine in their fight for freedom, sovereignty, and preservation of their national identity.

“On Our Way Home from the Revolution: Reflections on Ukraine” is a must read for anyone looking to learn more about Ukraine and gain a deeper understanding of the history of the region.